

Psalms 19

Two Books: Heavens and Word

The heavens declare the glory of God
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The heavens declare the glory of God; and the firmament sheweth his handywork.*
- 2 *Day unto day uttereth speech, and night unto night sheweth knowledge.*
- 3 *There is no speech nor language, where their voice is not heard.*
- 4 *Their line is gone out through all the earth, and their words to the end of the world. In them hath he set a tabernacle for the sun,*
- 5 *Which is as a bridegroom coming out of his chamber, and rejoiceth as a strong man to run a race.*
- 6 *His going forth is from the end of the heaven, and his circuit unto the ends of it: and there is nothing hid from the heat thereof.*
- 7 *The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul: the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple.*
- 8 *The statutes of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart: the commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes.*
- 9 *The fear of the LORD is clean, enduring for ever: the judgments of the LORD are true and righteous altogether.*
- 10 *More to be desired are they than gold, yea, than much fine gold: sweeter also than honey and the honeycomb.*
- 11 *Moreover by them is thy servant warned: and in keeping of them there is great reward.*
- 12 *Who can understand his errors? cleanse thou me from secret faults.*
- 13 *Keep back thy servant also from presumptuous sins; let them not have dominion over me: then shall I be upright, and I shall be innocent from the great transgression.*
- 14 *Let the words of my mouth, and the meditation of my heart, be acceptable in thy sight, O LORD, my strength, and my redeemer.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 19 pairs general revelation—creation’s wordless but universal testimony to God’s glory—with special revelation, the perfect, soul-reviving law of the Lord, before closing with a personal prayer for cleansing from hidden sin. Henry calls it one of the finest odes in praise of the Book of God’s works and the Book of His word together, and the movement from cosmic scale (the sun’s circuit) to intimate self-examination (“secret faults”) models how right theology should lead to personal holiness. C. S. Lewis famously called this one of the greatest poems in the Psalter.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The heavens “declare” God’s glory and the firmament shows His handiwork continuously, day unto day and night unto night, without literal speech yet with a message heard “to the end of the world.” Creation is a silent but universal preacher of God’s glory.

Verse 5-6

The sun is pictured as a bridegroom coming from his chamber, running its circuit with joy, its heat reaching everything under heaven—vivid imagery for the sun’s faithful, life-sustaining regularity as testimony to its Maker.

Verse 7-11

The focus shifts from creation to God’s law: perfect, converting the soul; sure, making wise the simple; right, rejoicing the heart; pure, enlightening the eyes; more to be desired than gold, sweeter than honey; and rewarding those who keep it with warning against hidden danger.

Verse 12-14

Personal application: who can discern his own errors? David asks to be cleansed from secret faults and kept back from presumptuous sins so they do not have dominion over him. The psalm ends with the well-known prayer that words and heart’s meditation be acceptable to the Lord, his strength and redeemer.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Creation and Scripture together testify to God’s glory and character, and the appropriate response to both “books” is not mere admiration but personal repentance and a heart-and-speech life pleasing to God.

Application for life today.

Let time in creation actually function as worship, not just relaxation—notice what the “heavens declare” and respond with praise. Treat Scripture as more desirable than gold and sweeter than honey by giving it unhurried attention, not just information-gathering. And regularly pray verses 12–14 over your own hidden blind spots, asking God to keep specific presumptuous sins from gaining “dominion” over you.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. When was the last time creation genuinely moved you toward worship rather than just wonder or distraction?

2. Which description of God’s law in verses 7–11 (perfect, sure, right, pure, sweet) do you most need to experience right now?

3. What “secret fault” might you ask God to reveal and cleanse today, using David’s prayer in verses 12–14?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).